

After spotlight dims

Mr. T is the subject of the most recent in Netflix’s “Untold” documentary series. He doesn’t like it, but maybe you will.



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“I am scared. But if I can help, I will do it. Even if it’s just saving a single person from being deported.”

ELVIRA ARZETA, who patrols hot spots frequented by federal agents targeting immigrants



A city on guard

By Andrew Carter, Caroline Kubzansky, Gregory Royal Pratt and Laura Rodríguez Presa CHICAGO TRIBUNE

In warmer months, Elvira Arzeta’s homemade popsicles sell with little trouble. She makes them from strawberries and mangoes, coconuts and limes. At \$2 each, she earns enough to keep her gas tank full while she remains on constant lookout for the threat of federal agents.

Soon, though, she knows it’ll get cooler, then cold. She worries about how she’ll pay for her gas when she sells fewer popsicles. She worries about a lot of things. When federal agents shot and killed two people earlier this year in Minneapolis, Arzeta, who lives just outside of Chicago, couldn’t sleep. That could’ve been her, she thought.

“I am scared,” Arzeta said, who still wears a whistle around her neck. “But if I can help, I will do it. Even if it’s just saving a single person from being deported.”

What the raids left behind after Operation Midway Blitz

Above: Elvira Arzeta patrols the western suburbs before dawn on Thursday. For over a year, Arzeta has headed out of her home at 5 a.m. to patrol hot spots frequented by federal agents targeting immigrants. STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

It has been a year this month since the Trump administration’s Operation Midway Blitz began. What it left behind can be measured in the number of neighborhood patrollers, like Arzeta, who are still making their daily rounds. It can be measured in places still coming back to life, where people keep a wary eye from apartment balconies and from behind cracks in window curtains.

By 5 a.m. most days, Arzeta is on the streets of Bensenville, a northwest suburb in the shadow of planes near O’Hare International Airport. Bensenville is a place, in some parts, of million-dollar homes and pristine lawns. Arzeta often drives to the other parts.

“Little Guatemala,” as locals know it, is one of those parts. It’s tucked between a pair of dead-end roads, near car dealerships and modest strip malls. Locals say that federal agents detained 35 people in a day there last year. Now Arzeta arrives to let those who remain know it’s safe for them to go to work.

That, for now, there’s no sign of Immigra-

See BLITZ on Page A4

How was COVID money used?

Illinois, Chicago, Cook County got \$11B in pandemic aid, but there were gaps in oversight and transparency

By Dan Petrella and A.D. Quig CHICAGO TRIBUNE

As the delta variant of COVID-19 surged in late summer 2021, Gov. JB Pritzker announced in Chicago’s East Garfield Park that the state was awarding \$250 million to help small businesses across Illinois battered by the pandemic.

Five years later, Pritzker is still touting the program, marking National Black Business Month in August with a campaign news release that cited the “Back to Business” grants as evidence of the reelection-seeking Democrat’s “support for Black-owned businesses.” In neither case did Pritzker identify where the state got the money for the grants — President Joe Biden’s American Rescue Plan Act, or ARPA.

The \$1.9 trillion pandemic relief package signed in March 2021 doled out \$350 billion in “State and Local Fiscal Recovery Funds” to governments nationwide. In Illinois, the state government received \$8.1 billion, Chicago got nearly \$1.9 billion and Cook County another \$1 billion. That cash came with largely flexible spending rules but rigid deadlines: It had to be allocated by the end of 2024 and spent by the end of this year.

In an attempt to figure out how the money was being spent and whether it helped the city, county and state recover from the pandemic, the Tribune and the University of Chicago’s Mansueto Institute for Urban Innovation launched a first-of-its-kind analysis of local data by scraping and collating thousands of pages of reports that the Democratic administrations of Pritzker, Cook County Board President Toni Preckwinkle, and Chicago mayors Lori Lightfoot and Brandon Johnson were required to submit to the federal government.

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INSIDE



PAUL VALADE/DAILY HERALD

Use of Flock cameras sparking discussions

Police say the tool is invaluable. But as misuse mounts, many wonder how to rein in the system. Chicagoland, Page A3

Trump hits nerve in visit to Ireland

The president waded into a complex situation, saying a unified Ireland would be “fantastic.” Nation & World, Page B5

Summer of Caleb is over. Things are about to get real

A pivotal season begins as Bears try to find a way to sustain success

By Sean Hammond CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The viral video was a Chicago sports fan’s dream.

Caleb Williams, with his beard freshly shaved, mustache remaining, looked into the TV camera and pointed. The camera panned from Williams in his front-row seat behind the Cubs dugout to the dugout itself, where Cubs star Pete Crow-Armstrong waved to his fan club before coolly turning back toward the action on the field.

When the camera panned back, Williams and Bulls forwards Caleb Wilson and Matas Buzelis pounded on the roof of the dugout as the Cubs faithful cheered behind them. With help from the two Calebs and Buzelis, the Wrigley Field crowd started chanting,

“P-C-A! P-C-A!”

It was Sept. 3, just hours after the Bears wrapped up their final practice of the summer. Coach Ben Johnson had given the players three days off over the Labor Day break, their last free weekend for a while.

Williams took advantage of the free time by heading to the ballpark to support his buddy Crow-Armstrong, who clubbed his 39th home run that night — and last week hit his 40th and 41st and is the odds-on favorite to win the National League MVP award.

“I like being out with the people supporting one of my friends, Cubbie Pete, and so it was just kind of spur of the moment,” Williams said. “(I) wanted to sit out there.”

It was, perhaps, the last great hurrah for the summer of Caleb.

Labor Day has come and gone. Kids are back in school. The hype has been a runaway train since the



Bears quarterback Caleb Williams flashes a smile from the first row behind the Cubs dugout in the eighth inning of a game against the Brewers on Sept. 3 at Wrigley Field. CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

BEARS OPENER

Bears at Panthers Noon Sunday, Fox-32

INSIDE SPORTS

How did Ben Johnson improve as a coach for Year 2 with the Bears? By digging into the details.

See BEARS on Page A2

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